Gerber

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The Gerber convention is a 4♣ response to a no-trumps bid. Like Blackwood, it is a slam investigation bid that asks partner how many aces he holds. The difference from Blackwood is that Gerber is only used for no-trumps. This is because 1NT-4NT is natural, inviting partner to bid 6NT.

When does Gerber apply? Here are some standard rules:

- An **immediate 4♣ response** to any no-trumps bid (or overcall) is Gerber.
- A **jump rebid of 4♣** in response to a natural no-trump bid is Gerber.

Agreements vary widely, so make sure to discuss it with your partners.

Responses to 4♣

Response	Meaning
4♦	0 or 4 aces.
4♥	1 ace.
4♠	2 aces.
4NT	3 aces.

Responses to 5♣

After hearing partner's response, the Gerber bidder can **bid 5♣ to ask for kings**.

Response	Meaning
5♦	0 or 4 kings.
5♥	1 king.
5♠	2 kings.
5NT	3 kings.

Examples

Opener	Responder

Opener	Responder
1NT (15-17)	4♣

Responder's hand:

♠ K53
♥ AJ
♦ K3
♣ KQJT73

Adding partner's 15-17 HCP to his own 17 HCP, responder knows that his side has 32-34 HCP. A small slam in no-trumps is possible, but the Gerber 4♣ bid can check if partner holds at least 2 aces.

Opener	Responder
2NT (20-21)	4♣

Responder's hand:

♠ K3
♥ KQJT98
♦ KT
♣ Q43

Responder is interested in 6♥ but worries about missing 2 aces. If partner shows all 4 aces, responder can bid 5♣ to ask for the club king, which would make 7NT cold.

Opener	Responder
3NT (25-27)	4♣

Responder's hand:

♠ T9
♥ T98
♦ 5
♣ AKJ9832

Responder is interested in a club slam.

Opener	Responder
1NT (15-17)	2♣[1]
2♥[2]	4♣

[1] Stayman, asking for a 4-card major.
[2] 4 hearts.

Responder's hand:

♠ KJ32
♥ KQJ2

♦ AJ82
♣ 3

Gerber can also be used as a **jump rebid** after a Stayman sequence. Here, responder is interested in 6♥ but is missing 3 aces.

Opener	Responder
2♣[1]	2♦[2]
2NT (22-24)	4♣

[1] Strong, artificial.
[2] Waiting.

If a trump suit hasn't been identified yet, then 4♣ is Gerber after any natural no-trumps rebid.

Opener	Responder
2NT	3♣[1]
3♦[2]	4♣

[1] Stayman.
[2] Denies a 4-card major.

Responder's hand:

♠ KJ32
♥ KT92
♦ —
♣ AT983

4♣ is NOT Gerber. It is natural because it was not a jump.

Other Considerations

- Gerber requires a lot of partnership discussion. It can be misidentified as a splinter bid (showing a club singleton/void), or as club support if partner previously bid clubs.
- Gerber should not be used with a void.

Origins

Gerber was invented by American expert John Gerber.

See also

- 5NT Pick a Slam
  A conventional 5NT bid that asks partner to choose a small slam.